

ENGLISH LANGUAGE PAPER 4

PART A Group Interaction

This article appeared in a local newspaper:

The value of doing chores

One of the traditions of Japanese education is that students do *soji* (cleaning). *Soji* starts after lunch and lasts for about 20 minutes. This happens four times a week and, on the last day of each semester, there is a longer cleaning session called *o-soji* (big cleaning).

During the entire cleaning time, the public announcement system blasts cheerful marching music. Every class is responsible for cleaning its own classroom and two other places in the school.

Through cleaning, children develop values such as responsibility, cooperation and discipline.

Similarly, research shows that when children help out with home duties or chores, they actually do better in school, and are more thoughtful and considerate. Even if they are asked to be responsible for only a certain area, like their own bedroom, they show more consideration to other family members and are less likely to mess up other areas.

Children who participate in everyday responsibilities are also found to be more positive and have a stronger sense of self-worth. Interestingly, the effects are comparable to those of playing with friends.

When children are contributing, they feel needed and bonded to the family. They see that they have an important role to play, and consideration and helpfulness become second nature to them.



Japanese students cleaning during the collective cleaning time, soji.

As part of the school's environment improvement campaign, your principal would like to add cleaning sessions to the timetable. Your class teacher has asked your group to discuss this. You may want to talk about:

- benefits of adding cleaning sessions to the timetable
- possible problems of requiring students to clean the school
- cleaning tasks that are suitable for different forms
- anything else you think is important

PART B Individual Response

1. Do you like doing housework?
2. Do you help out with housework?
3. What can be done to make cleaning less boring?
4. How can parents motivate their children to do housework?
5. Do you agree that teenagers are messier than adults?
6. Do you agree that housework can bring family members closer?
7. Should cleaning staff receive more respect in society?
8. Will technology change housework in the future?